



Safe hands: Alex Carey's work behind the stumps was one of the quieter but more decisive factors in Australia's early control of the Ashes. GETTY IMAGES

the near irrelevance of spin across the series. This Ashes was decided almost entirely by fast bowling, and that too worked decisively in Australia's favour.

Spin barely featured from either side. Nathan Lyon's 53 overs in Adelaide were the exception. Australia went to the extraordinary length of selecting no frontline spinner at the SCG, the first time it had done so in 138 years of Test cricket at the venue. On the two pitches that offered turn, at Adelaide and Sydney, Shoaib Bashir, the spinner England has backed of late, was nowhere to be seen.

The numbers underline how skewed the series was. Across five Tests, 1,279.3 overs were bowled. Only 191 of them came from spin.

Australia's spinners bowled 95

overs for eight wickets at an average of 41.25. England's bowled 96 overs for seven wickets at an average of 62.71. The 1,146 balls of spin in this series were the fewest in any Ashes series since 1910 and the third fewest in any Test series of five or more matches.

Australia bowled 657.2 overs in total, taking 96 wickets at an average of 26.69. England bowled 622.1 overs, took 79 wickets and conceded at 33.53. The gap was not marginal. It was decisive.

In a contest so dominated by pace, the imbalance in fast-bowling resources became even more damaging for England. When spin offers control or respite, fast bowlers can be rotated and protected. Here, there was no such cushion. Seamers carried the burden almost entirely. Australia was equipped for that reality. England was not.

Travis Head's impact worked on a different axis but was no less decisive. His promotion to open after tea on day two in Perth, prompted by

Usman Khawaja's injury, proved a turning point. Until then, openers had failed. Not a single run had been scored for the first wicket across three innings. Head changed that instantly. His 69-ball hundred did more than accelerate the scoring. It altered the psychology of the contest. England had been well placed at one point. After lunch on day two at Perth, it led by 99 runs with one wicket down. Suddenly, it was chasing.

That innings exposed England's lack of readiness. Its bowlers, undercooked and lightly loaded, could not sustain pace or pressure. Plans shifted ball by ball. While Mitchell Starc and Scott Boland bowled at the stumps, England resorted to short-pitched bowling, which Head fed off, playing hooks and cuts with abandon.

The hundreds in Adelaide and Sydney confirmed this was no one-off. In Adelaide, as England began to question its own attacking instincts, Head exploited hesitation